

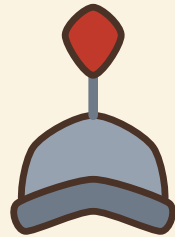
Hua Mulan

an old ballad, told again



Hua Mulan

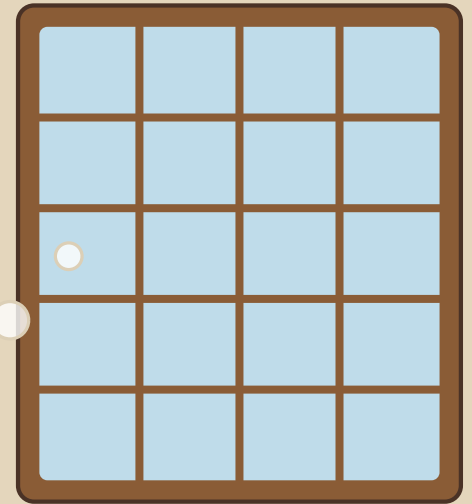
after the Ballad of Mulan



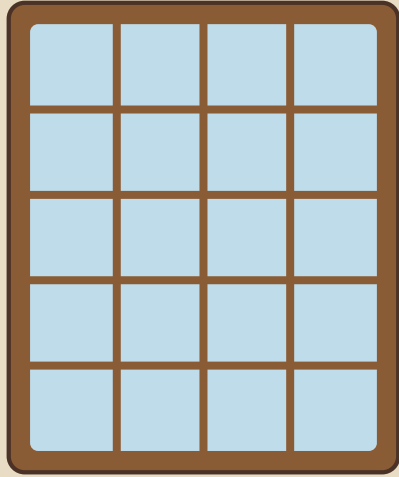
This book belongs to

A retelling of the Ballad of Mulan, written down in China around the sixth century.

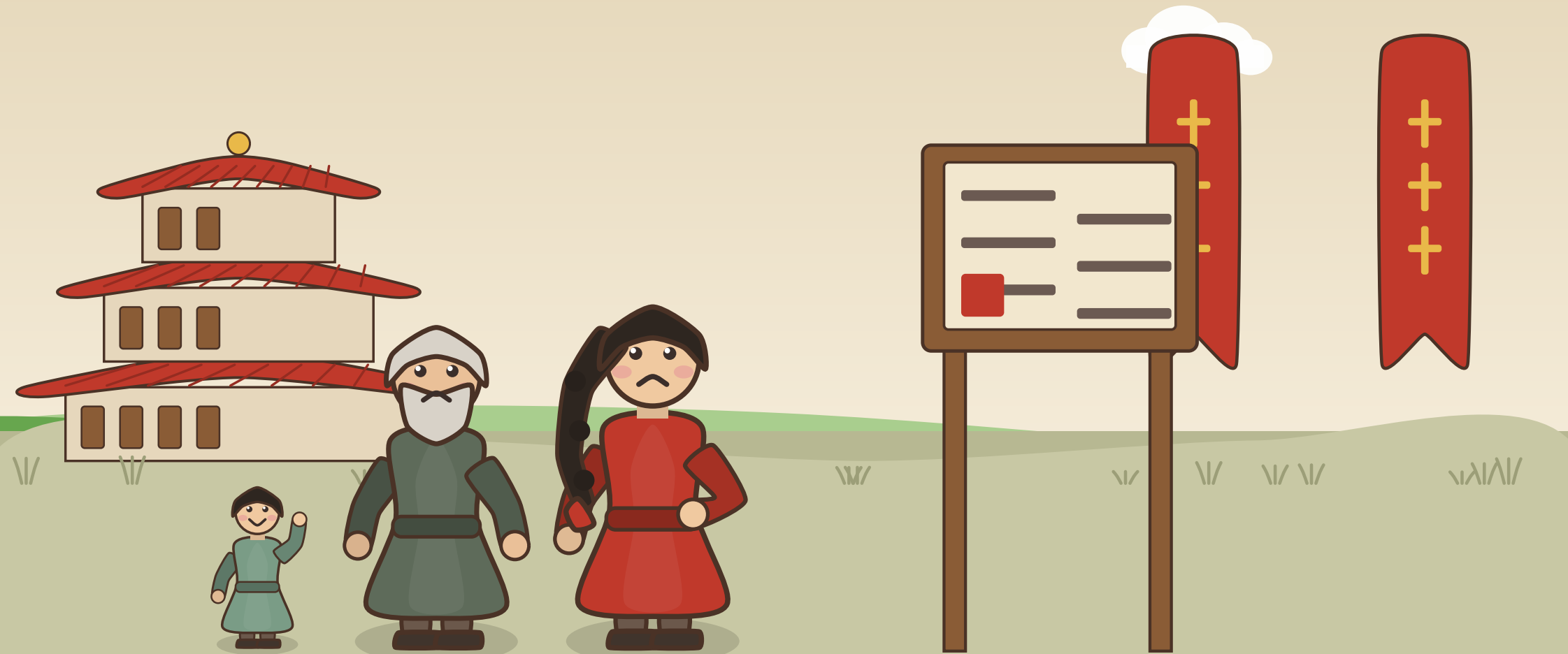
Illustrations drawn as vector art. Made to be read aloud.



Click, click, click went the loom by the window.
But this morning there was no clicking. There was only Mulan, sitting still, and
sighing.



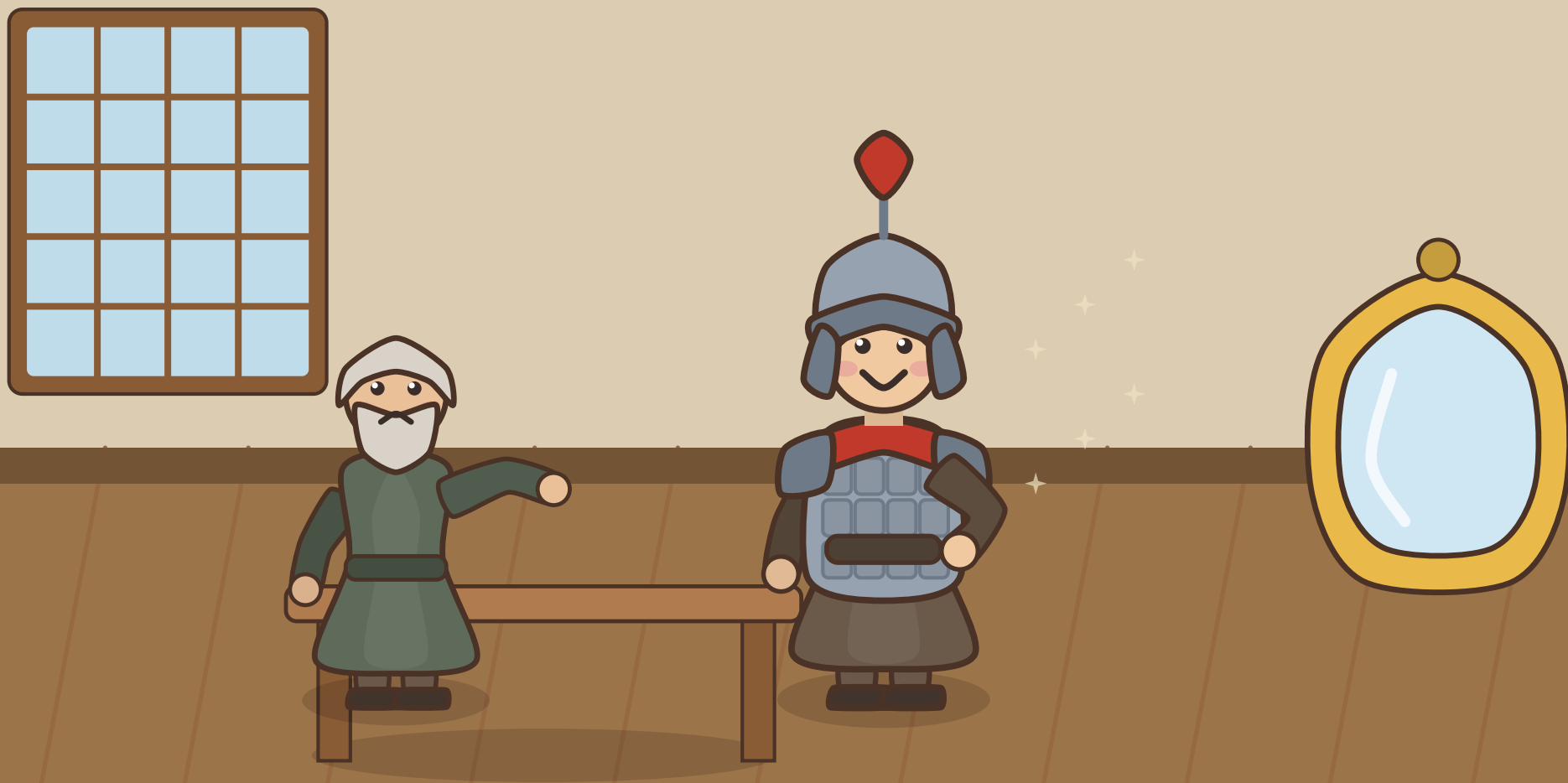
“What are you thinking of?” asked her mother.
“Nothing,” said Mulan. “Only the notice in the square.”



The Khan was calling for soldiers. Twelve scrolls of names, and her father's name on every one.
But her father was old, and there was no elder brother — only a little brother, still losing his teeth.



So Mulan went out and bought a horse in the east market, and a saddle in the west, and a bridle in the south, and a long whip in the north.



In the morning she tied up her hair and put on her father's armour.
It was heavy. She stood up straight anyway.



At dawn she said goodbye to her mother and father. That night she camped by the Yellow River.

She could not hear her mother calling her any more. She could only hear the water going by.



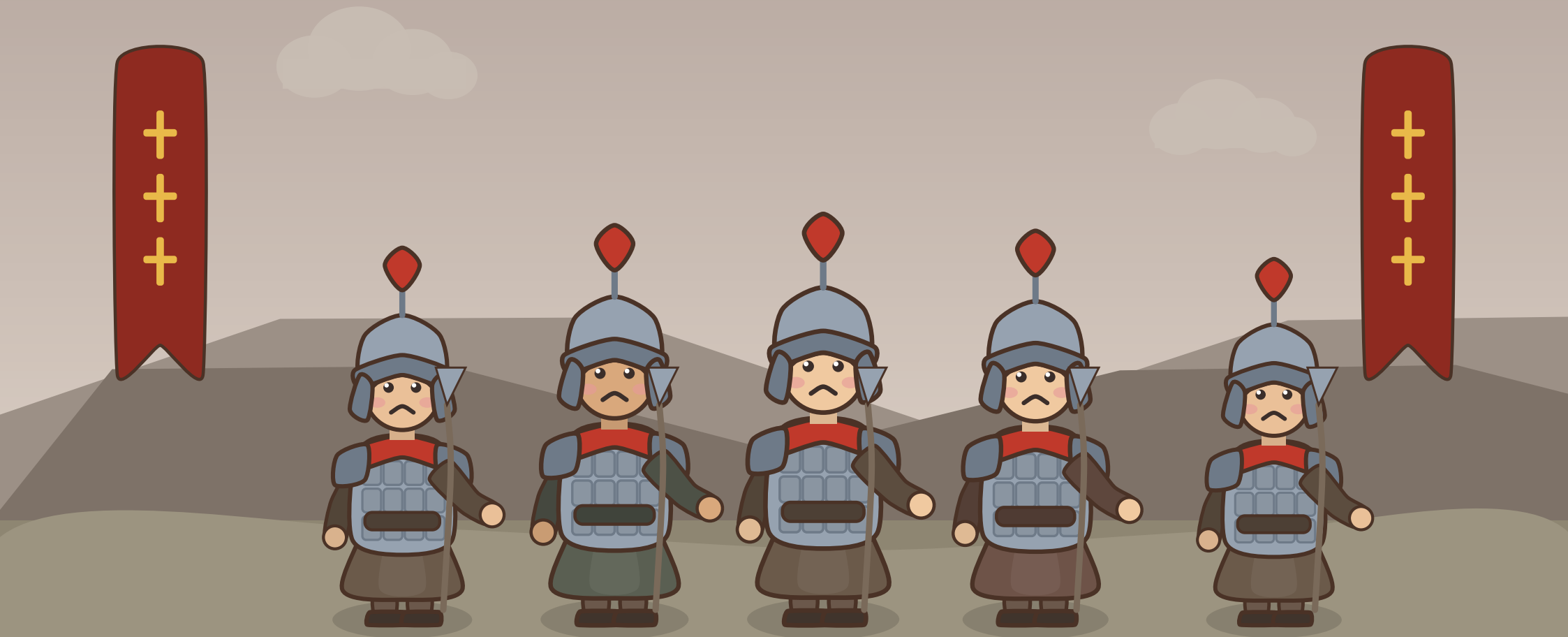
At dawn she left the Yellow River. That night she camped on the Black Mountain.
She could not hear her father calling her any more. She could only hear the horses of the northern hills.



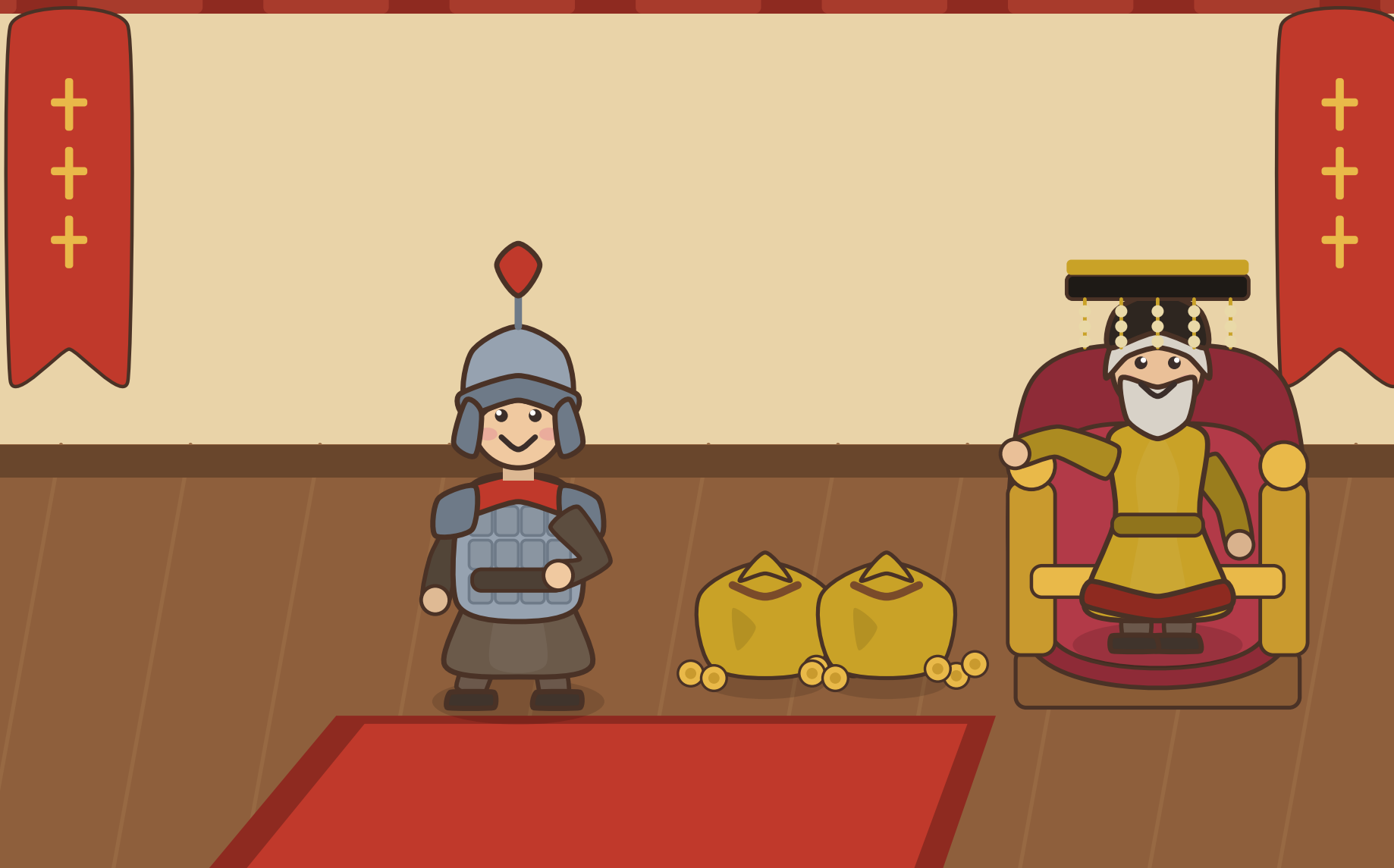
Ten thousand miles she rode to the war, over passes and mountains, flying like a bird.



The cold air carried the sound of the watchman's rattle.
The moon came out, and shone on all the iron coats, and everybody thought of home.



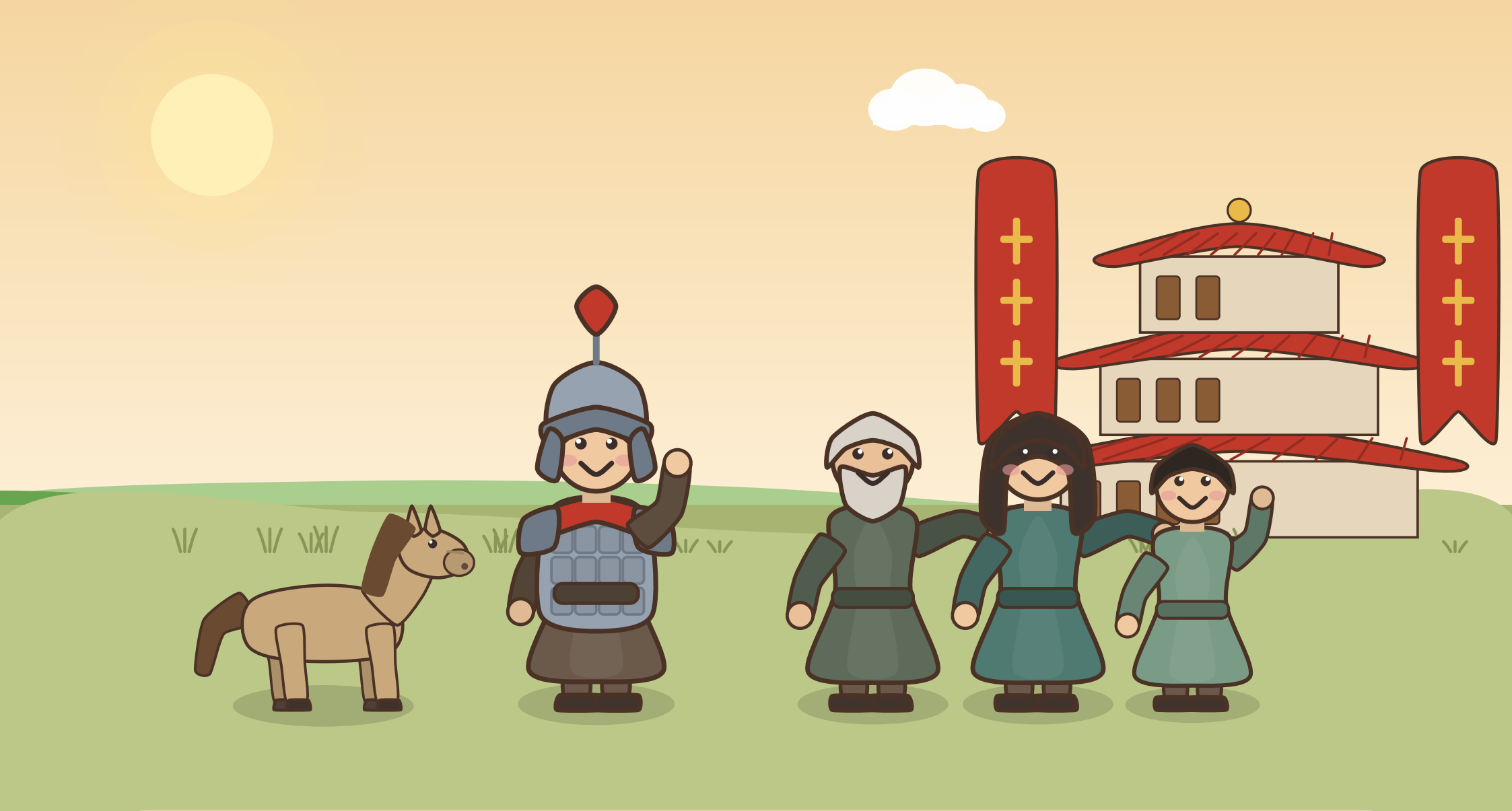
For twelve years she fought. Generals fell. Soldiers came back grey.
And in all that time not one of them guessed.



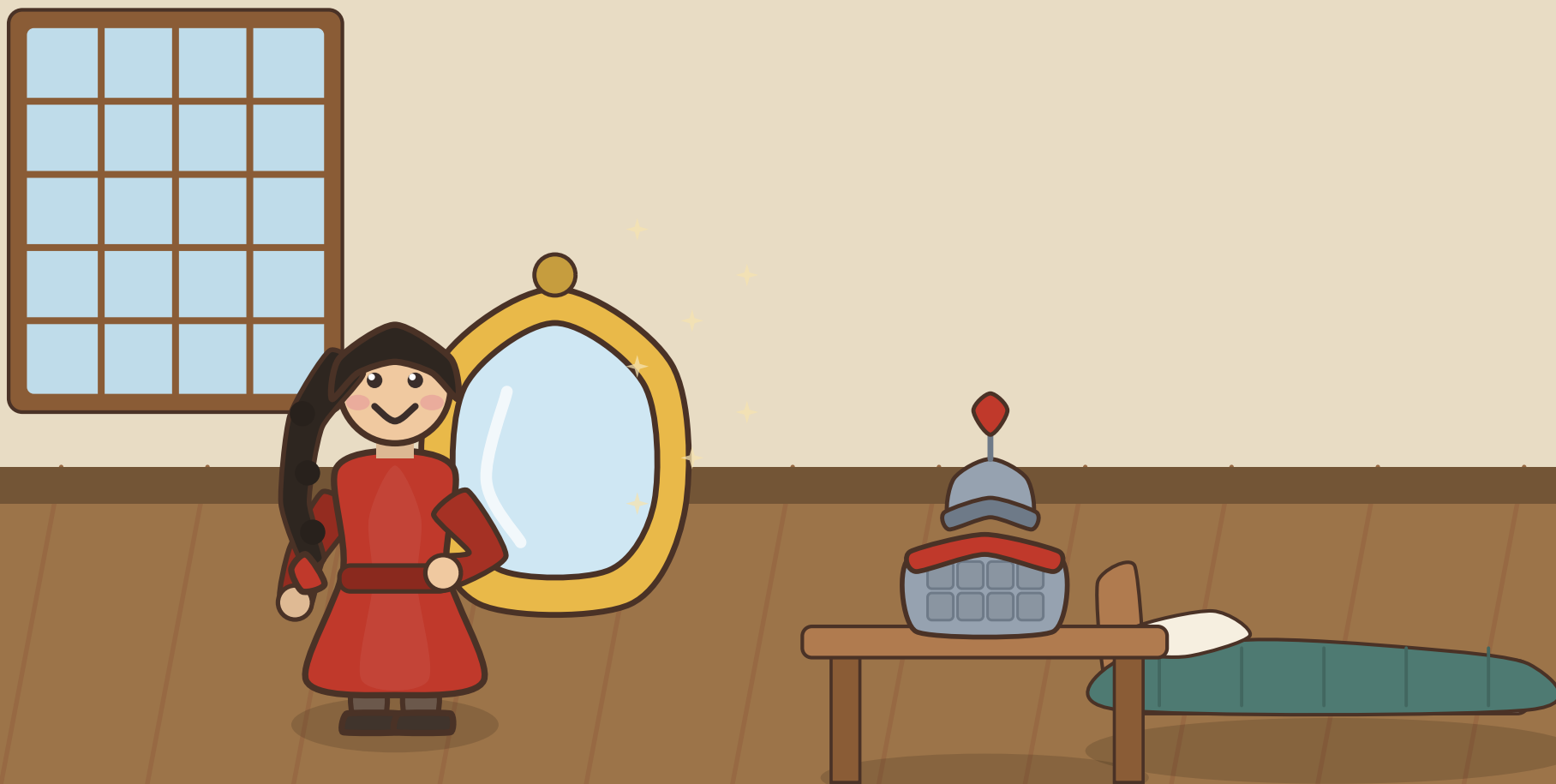
When it was over she stood in front of the Emperor himself, who offered her a great office, and a thousand pieces of gold.



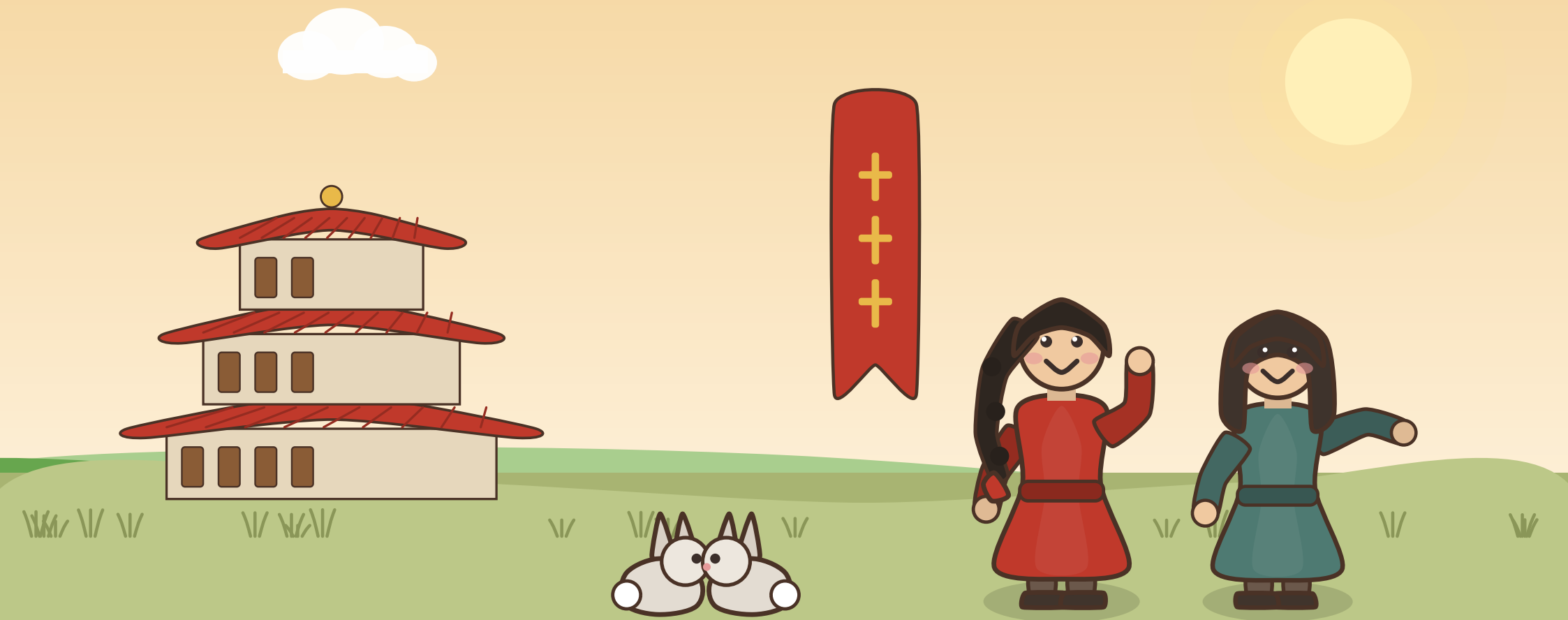
"I do not want an office," said Mulan. "Lend me a fast camel and let me go home."



Her mother and father came out to the gate to meet her. Her sister ran to put on her best dress. Her little brother — not so little now — sharpened the knife for the sheep.



She opened the door of her old room, and sat on her old bed, and took off her armour, and put on her yellow skirt, and did her hair at the window. When she came out, her comrades stared. Twelve years — and they had never known she was a girl.



The End

**“Two hares run side by side —
how can you tell which is which?”**

